Coaching Codex



COACHING CODEX · GUIDE 12 · AI SPREADSHEETS & DATA

Ask Your Data: Turn Sales Numbers into Simple Insights with AI

Upload anonymized numbers, ask clear questions about trends and profit, and leave each month with charts plus three decisions you can act on.

Safe	3	1
anonymized export before you ask	decisions every month from your numbers	page summary with charts you checked

START HERE

Your sales sheet already knows. You just need to ask.

Most owners have the numbers. What they lack is time to dig. AI can help you spot trends, compare best sellers with profit, and explain slow months — if you prepare a safe, anonymized export and check every answer against your sheet. This guide gives you the prompts, the privacy rules, and a monthly routine that ends with three clear decisions.

Safe
Export
Strip personal data and secrets before anything touches an AI chat.

Ask
Prompts
Trends, best sellers vs profit, slow months — facts only, no invented totals.

3
Decisions
A monthly one-page summary with charts and three actions you chose.

What's inside

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AI DRAFTS INSIGHTS. YOUR SHEET OWNS THE NUMBERS.

Never let the assistant invent sales totals, margins or customer counts. Paste only anonymized figures you already trust, then verify every claim against the original spreadsheet before you change prices, stock or marketing.

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SECTION 01 · THE BASICS

What 'ask your data' means (and what it doesn't)

You describe columns and paste anonymized totals or sample rows. The AI helps you see patterns in plain English. It does not replace your accounting software, and it must not guess missing figures.

Great at	Be careful with
Explaining trends you already calculated	Inventing revenue or margin you did not provide
Comparing products when you give units and profit	Calling something 'most profitable' without cost data
Suggesting chart types for a one-page summary	Claiming causation ('ads caused this') without proof
Listing three decision options from your facts	Prices, tax or forecasts you never confirmed
Rewriting a messy insight into owner-friendly bullets	Pasting real customer names, emails or card details

The one-line rule

Facts in, insights out — then you check. Treat every answer like a sharp analyst who has never seen your business before: useful drafts, zero authority until verified.

PROMPT · TEST HONESTY ON A DATA QUESTION

I run [TYPE OF BUSINESS] in [CITY]. Here are confirmed monthly totals (USD) from my sales sheet:
[PASTE ONLY FIGURES YOU VERIFIED]
Answer: [YOUR QUESTION].
Use only these figures. Do not invent any number. List which parts of your answer I should double-check on my original sheet, and why.

EXERCISE 1 · YOUR THREE DATA QUESTIONS (3 MINUTES)

Write the three questions you most want answered from your sales numbers this month (for example: which product makes money, which month is slowest, where to focus marketing).

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SECTION 02 · SAFE EXPORT

Prepare a safe, anonymized export

Before you upload or paste anything, make a copy that a stranger could read without learning who your customers are. Structure and numbers help AI; personal details do not.

1. Duplicate your sales sheet. Work only on the copy.
2. Keep columns you need for insight: date, product/service code, qty, revenue USD, cost USD (if you have it), channel or region codes.
3. Remove or replace: customer names, emails, phones, addresses, invoice numbers that identify a person, notes with private details.
4. Replace product names with codes if they reveal client work (P1, P2) — keep a private key offline.
5. Export CSV or copy a small sample into the chat. Prefer aggregates (monthly totals) when a full dump is unnecessary.

PROMPT · ANONYMIZE A SAMPLE BEFORE ASKING

I will paste a small sample from a sales spreadsheet. Replace any personal names, emails, phones, addresses and identifiable invoice numbers with placeholders like [NAME], [EMAIL], [PHONE], [INV]. Keep dates, product codes, quantities and USD amounts. Return only the anonymized sample.

Sample:
[PASTE]

PROMPT · CONFIRM COLUMNS ARE SAFE TO DISCUSS

Here are my column headers only (no rows):
[LIST HEADERS]
I want to ask about trends and profit. Tell me which columns are fine to share as aggregates, which should stay offline, and what minimum fields I need for: monthly trend, best seller by units, and best seller by estimated profit. Ask if a header meaning is unclear.

REMOVE THIS BEFORE YOU UPLOAD BUSINESS DATA TO AI

Never paste passwords, full card or bank numbers, tax IDs, employee salaries, or customers' personal contact details into a free or personal AI account. If you serve UK or EU customers, minimize personal data in any external tool. This guide is general information, not legal advice.

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SECTION 03 · CORE PROMPTS

Prompts for trends, best sellers and slow months

Ask one clear question at a time. Give only confirmed figures. Demand that the assistant refuse to invent missing months or products.

PROMPT · MONTHLY TREND

I run [TYPE OF BUSINESS]. Confirmed revenue by month (USD), from my sheet:
[LIST MONTH: AMOUNT — only months you verified]
Describe the trend in 4 short bullets a busy owner can read in 30 seconds. Flag the highest and lowest months using only these figures. Do not invent any month or amount. If a comparison needs a missing month, say so and ask me.

PROMPT · BEST SELLERS BY UNITS

Confirmed unit sales for [MONTH YEAR] (anonymized product codes):
[CODE: UNITS — verified]
Rank by units sold. Give a one-line note on what 'best seller' means here (units only, not profit). Do not add products I did not list. Ask if I have cost data before talking about profit.

PROMPT · SLOW MONTHS

Confirmed monthly revenue (USD):
[PASTE]
Which months are slowest relative to the others in this list? Suggest 3 practical questions I should ask myself about staffing, stock or marketing in those months. Do not invent causes. Do not invent numbers.

ONE QUESTION PER CHAT TURN

Mixing trend + profit + marketing advice in one prompt invites invented stories. Finish the numbers question first, check it, then ask for decision options.

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SECTION 04 · PROFIT VS VOLUME

Your best-selling product may not be your most profitable

Units sold and profit are different questions. If you only track revenue, say so. If you have cost per unit, you can ask which line actually makes money.

If you have...	You can ask...	You still must...
Units only	What sold the most?	Not call it 'most profitable'
Revenue only	What brought the most sales USD?	Remember revenue ≠ margin
Revenue + cost per unit	Which product has the best estimated profit?	Check costs are current
Revenue + hours spent	Which service pays best per hour?	Use your real time logs

PROMPT · BEST SELLER VS PROFIT

I run [TYPE OF BUSINESS]. For [MONTH YEAR], confirmed figures (USD, anonymized codes):
[CODE | UNITS | REVENUE | COST PER UNIT — only rows you verified]
1) Rank by units sold.
2) Estimate profit per code as (revenue − units×cost). Show working.
3) Say clearly if the top seller by units is NOT the top by estimated profit.
Use only these rows. If cost is missing for a row, exclude it from the profit ranking and tell me. Do not invent costs.

PROMPT · WHAT TO DO NEXT (OPTIONS ONLY)

Based only on this verified ranking:
[PASTE YOUR CHECKED RANKING]
List 3 decision options for next month (for example: promote X, raise price on Y, reduce stock of Z). For each option, state which figure supports it. Do not invent new figures. Do not tell me what I 'must' do — options only.

EXERCISE 2 · VOLUME VS PROFIT ON YOUR SHEET

Pick one month. Write your top product by units and, if you have costs, your top by estimated profit. Note if they differ.

Top by units:

Top by estimated profit (or 'costs unknown'):

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SECTION 05 · SUMMARY PAGE

Charts and a one-page summary

A useful monthly data page is short: trend line or bars, top products, one slow-month note, and three decisions. AI can propose the layout and chart types. You plot from verified numbers.

1 · VERIFIED TOTALS
Months, products, USD you checked

▶

2 · CHART CHOICE
Bars for months; simple rank for products

▶

3 · ONE INSIGHT LINE
What changed vs last month (your words)

▶

4 · THREE DECISIONS
Actions you chose, each tied to a figure

PROMPT · ONE-PAGE SUMMARY LAYOUT

I run [TYPE OF BUSINESS]. I will fill a one-page monthly data summary for [MONTH YEAR].
I have verified: monthly revenue for the last [N] months (USD), top [N] products by units, and [cost data YES/NO].
Propose a simple one-page layout: which chart types, which three metric callouts, and a box for 3 decisions. Do not invent sample numbers. Ask if anything essential is missing.

PROMPT · DRAFT THE INSIGHT PARAGRAPH

Confirmed facts for [MONTH YEAR] (USD):
[PASTE ONLY VERIFIED BULLETS]
Write a 5-sentence owner summary: what went up, what went down, best seller vs profit note, slow-month note, and a blank line labelled 'My 3 decisions'. Use only these facts. No invented causes.

EXERCISE 3 · SKETCH YOUR ONE-PAGER

On paper, box out: (1) month title (2) trend chart area (3) top 3 products (4) three decision lines. You will fill it after Section 06.

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SECTION 06 · VERIFY

Check every insight before you act

A confident paragraph can still mis-read your columns. Build a five-minute check into every ask-your-data session.

- [ ] Every figure in the AI answer appears on my anonymized export or original sheet
- [ ] No month, product or margin was invented
- [ ] 'Best seller' and 'most profitable' are labelled correctly for the data I have
- [ ] Charts match the same totals I used in the prompt
- [ ] I still have the Raw copy; nothing sensitive stayed in a personal AI chat

PROMPT · FACT-CHECK THIS INSIGHT

Here is an insight draft:
[PASTE AI OUTPUT]
Here are my confirmed source figures:
[PASTE]
List every number or claim in the draft. Mark each CONFIRMED, NOT IN SOURCE, or UNCLEAR. Rewrite the draft using only CONFIRMED items. Do not add new figures.

Check	Pass?	Note
All totals match the sheet		
No invented products or months		
Profit claims only where costs exist		
Personal data removed from chat		

REPAIR PHRASE THAT WORKS

When the AI invents a figure, reply: **Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else.** Then re-run your checklist.

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SECTION 07 · MONTHLY ROUTINE

Your monthly ask-your-data routine

Do this once a month, same day if you can. Estimate: 45–75 minutes once the export habit is set. Times vary by sheet size.

1. **Export & anonymize** (10–15 min): copy sheet, strip personal fields, save Raw + Anon files.
2. **Trend question** (10 min): paste verified monthly totals; get a short trend; check figures.
3. **Best seller vs profit** (15 min): units ranking; profit ranking only if costs are current.
4. **One-page summary** (15 min): chart from your tool, insight paragraph, three decisions you write yourself.
5. **Close the loop** (5 min): delete sensitive chats if needed; save your three best prompts for next month.

PROMPT · FACILITATE MY THREE DECISIONS

I have verified these facts for [MONTH YEAR]:
[PASTE CHECKED BULLETS]
Help me choose 3 decisions for next month. For each candidate decision, restate the supporting figure in my list. Offer options in three buckets: promote, price/stock, and operations. Do not invent figures. End by asking me which three I pick — do not pick for me.

- Same calendar reminder each month (for example, the first Monday)
- One folder: Raw / Anon / Summaries
- Three decisions written in your own words on the one-pager
- No customer personal data in a personal AI account

DECISIONS ARE YOURS

AI can list options. It does not know your cash, suppliers or team capacity. Never change prices or cut a product line on an unchecked chat answer.

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SECTION 08 · HABIT

Your 7-day starter plan and tracker

Use the first week to set up the export habit and run one full cycle on last month's numbers.

Day	Action	Time (est.)	Done
1	Pick the sales sheet; save a Raw copy	10 min	
2	Build the anonymized export; test the anonymize prompt	20 min	
3	Run the monthly trend prompt; verify every figure	20 min	
4	Rank best sellers; add profit only if costs are ready	25 min	
5	Draft the one-page layout and charts in your sheet tool	25 min	
6	Write three decisions; run the fact-check prompt	20 min	
7	Save prompts; set next month's calendar reminder	10 min	

Times are rough estimates and vary by data volume.

PROMPT · WEEKLY REVIEW

This week I asked AI about my sales data for: [TASKS].
What worked: [WINS]. What didn't: [PROBLEMS].
Rewrite my best data prompt so a beginner could reuse it monthly. List 3 checks I must never skip. Do not invent any of my business numbers.

Safety checklist

- [ ] I verified every figure against my sheet before acting
- [ ] No real customer personal data in a personal AI account
- [ ] My three decisions are written in my own words and tied to checked figures

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FIRST WIN · FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Your first win, start to finish

Walk through one data question for a made-up neighborhood bakery in Austin. Nothing here is a real business, real customers or live AI output.

Example input	Value
Business	Oak Street Bakery (fictional), Austin
Month	March 2026
Verified rows	P1 Croissant: 400 units, USD 2,000 revenue, USD 0.90 cost/unit · P2 Cake slice: 120 units, USD 1,440 revenue, USD 4.00 cost/unit · P3 Coffee: 600 units, USD 1,800 revenue, USD 0.55 cost/unit
Question	Which product actually makes money — units vs estimated profit?

EXAMPLE COMPLETED PROMPT

I run a neighborhood bakery in Austin (fictional example for practice).
Month: March 2026.
Confirmed rows (USD, anonymized codes):
P1 | 400 units | revenue 2000 | cost per unit 0.90
P2 | 120 units | revenue 1440 | cost per unit 4.00
P3 | 600 units | revenue 1800 | cost per unit 0.55

1) Rank by units sold.
2) Estimate profit as revenue minus units×cost; show working.
3) Say clearly if the top seller by units is NOT the top by estimated profit.
Use only these rows. Do not invent products, months or costs. If a fact is missing, ask me before answering.

Copy it, open your AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot), paste and send. Then compare what you get with this:

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Units rank: P3 (600), P1 (400), P2 (120). Estimated profit: P1 = 2000 − 400×0.90 = USD 1,640; P3 = 1800 − 600×0.55 = USD 1,470; P2 = 1440 − 120×4.00 = USD 960. Top by units is P3 (coffee); top by estimated profit is P1 (croissant). They are not the same.

Checks before use

- [ ] Every unit, revenue and cost matches the input rows.
- [ ] Profit working is shown; no extra products were added.
- [ ] The answer separates 'best seller by units' from 'most profitable'.
- [ ] A human compared the math to the sheet before any stock or price change.

USE IT

Copy the checked ranking into your own notes or sheet. The webpage does not change your files.

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GUIDED TASK

Ask for a monthly sales trend

When to use it: You have verified monthly revenue totals and want a short plain-English trend. **Prepare:** Confirmed revenue by month in USD (only months you checked); Anonymized export or aggregate list — no customer personal data.

Question	Example answer
Paste confirmed monthly revenue (USD), one month per line.	October 2025: 8200 November 2025: 9100 December 2025: 12400 January 2026: 7800 February 2026: 8100 March 2026: 9400
What should the trend summary emphasize?	Highest and lowest months, and whether March recovered from January
Describe your business in one sentence.	A neighborhood bakery in Austin

PROMPT TEMPLATE

About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Confirmed monthly revenue (USD):
[MONTH: AMOUNT USD]
Focus: [FOCUS]
Describe the trend in 4 short bullets a busy owner can read in 30 seconds. Flag the highest and lowest months using only these figures. Do not invent any month or amount. If a comparison needs a missing month, say so and ask me.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

December is the high at USD 12,400; January is the low at USD 7,800. February and March rise from January but stay below November–December. March at USD 9,400 recovers from January yet is not a new high. No months outside your list were used.

Checks before use

- [ ] Highest and lowest months match your pasted figures.
- [ ] No month or amount was invented.
- [ ] The summary stays within your stated focus.
- [ ] You compared bullets to the original sheet before sharing them.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented a month or amount	"Remove every figure I did not provide. Use only this list: [PASTE]. Change nothing else."
Assumed a cause (ads, weather, etc.)	"Remove all cause claims. Keep only descriptions of the numbers I gave."
Too long	"Cut to 4 short bullets. Keep the highest and lowest months."

Next action: Paste the checked bullets onto your one-page summary, then run the best-seller task if you have product rows.

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GUIDED TASK

Compare best sellers vs estimated profit

When to use it: You want to know if your top seller by units is also your most profitable line. **Prepare:** Anonymized product codes with units and revenue for one month; Cost per unit if you have it (skip profit ranking if costs are missing).

Question	Example answer
Which month and year?	March 2026
Paste verified product rows (code, units, revenue USD, cost per unit if known).	P1, 400, 2000, 0.90 P2, 120, 1440, 4.00 P3, 600, 1800, 0.55
Describe your business in one sentence.	A neighborhood bakery in Austin

PROMPT TEMPLATE

About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Month: [MONTH YEAR]
Confirmed rows (USD, anonymized codes):
[CODE, UNITS, REVENUE, COST/UNIT]
1) Rank by units sold.
2) If cost per unit is present, estimate profit as revenue minus units×cost and show working. If cost is missing for a row, exclude it from the profit ranking and say so.
3) Say clearly if the top seller by units is NOT the top by estimated profit.
Use only these rows. Do not invent products, costs or months. If an essential fact is missing, ask me before answering.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Units: P3, P1, P2. Estimated profit: P1 USD 1,640; P3 USD 1,470; P2 USD 960. Top by units (P3) is not the top by estimated profit (P1).

Checks before use

- [ ] Unit and revenue figures match your rows.
- [ ] Profit math uses only costs you provided.
- [ ] The answer does not call a units leader 'most profitable' without cost support.
- [ ] No real customer personal data was pasted.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented a cost	“Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else.”
Called units leader most profitable	“Separate the units ranking from the profit ranking. Do not use the word profitable unless cost data is present.”
Added products I did not list	“Remove every product code not in my rows. Use only: [LIST].”

Next action: Write three decision options tied to the checked ranking, then put them on your one-pager.

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GUIDED TASK

Build a one-page summary with three decisions

When to use it: You have checked trend and product figures and want a monthly page you can act on. **Prepare:** Verified trend bullets and product ranking; Willingness to choose three decisions yourself (AI lists options only).

Question	Example answer
Paste only verified facts for this month (trend + products).	March 2026 revenue USD 9,400 (up from February 8,100). Low month in set: January 7,800. Top units: P3. Top estimated profit: P1.
Any hard constraints for next month?	No new staff hires; keep menu prices fixed in April
Describe your business in one sentence.	A neighborhood bakery in Austin

PROMPT TEMPLATE

About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Verified facts:
[VERIFIED FACTS]
Constraints: [CONSTRAINTS]
Propose a simple one-page layout (trend chart suggestion, top products block, notes line).
Then list decision OPTIONS in three buckets: promote, price/stock, and operations. Each option must restate a supporting figure from my facts.
Do not invent figures. Do not pick my final three decisions for me — end by asking which three I choose.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Layout: title March 2026; bar chart of months you already verified; callouts for revenue and January low; product block showing P3 units vs P1 profit; box labelled My 3 decisions. Options (examples): promote P1 (highest estimated profit USD 1,640 class figure from your ranking); review P3 stock vs margin; plan a light January staffing note using the USD 7,800 low — without hiring if that is your constraint. You choose the final three.

Checks before use

- [ ] Every figure on the page appears in your verified facts.
- [ ] No decision is presented as mandatory.
- [ ] Constraints you listed were respected.
- [ ] You wrote the final three decisions in your own words.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented a figure	“Remove every sample total not in my facts. Keep only layout and options tied to: [FACTS].”
Picked decisions for me	“List options only. End by asking which three I choose. Change nothing else.”
Ignored a constraint	“Replace this assumption with: [FACT]. Respect this constraint: [CONSTRAINT].”

Next action: Fill the one-pager in your spreadsheet tool, set next month's reminder, and archive the Raw and Anon files.

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WHAT'S NEXT

Numbers you trust. Questions that land. Three decisions a month.

A safe export, fact-only prompts, and a one-page summary with decisions you chose: that is asking your data without the overwhelm.

AI Spreadsheets for Non-Techies: Formulas, Clean-Up & Reports

Get the formulas and clean sheets that feed better data questions.

50 Copy-Paste AI Prompts for Small Business Owners

Fifty ready prompts for marketing, sales, service, admin and planning.

Custom AI Assistants for Your Business: Build Your First GPT, Gem or Project

Save your monthly data prompts as a reusable assistant.

Automate Your Inbox and Customer Replies with AI

Turn insights into clearer customer follow-ups you still check.

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